

800–775 BCE

The Greeks create new colonies in the eastern Mediterranean and southern Italy.



Greek trireme

750–700 BCE

The first great works of Greek literature are composed by Homer – *The Iliad* and *The Odyssey*.



Oil lamp decorated with images from *The Odyssey*

620–510 BCE

Many Greek city-states are ruled by tyrants who hold absolute power.

490 BCE

The Persian King Darius I invades Greece, but is defeated by the Athenians at the Battle of Marathon.

431–404 BCE

Sparta and Athens fight the Peloponnesian War, with great loss of life on both sides.

371 BCE

General Epaminondas defeats the Spartans at Leuctra. Thebes becomes Greece's most powerful city-state.

338 BCE

Philip, King of Macedon, defeats Athens and Thebes at Chaeronea, and conquers most of Greece.

334–323 BCE

Philip's son Alexander the Great invades and conquers the Persian Empire.

31 BCE

Rome captures all the Greek colonies, ending with Egypt in 31 BCE.



Alexander the Great on his horse Bucephalus

31 BCE

ARCHAIC PERIOD

800–500 BCE

By around 800 BCE, Greece begins to recover. City-states hold political power, backed by armies of citizen-soldiers. The Greeks begin to found colonies abroad.

CLASSICAL PERIOD

500–323 BCE

During the classical period, literature, art, politics, athletics, and theatre flourish, especially around the main centre, Athens.

HELLENISTIC PERIOD

323–31 BCE

Alexander the Great begins the Hellenistic Age in 323 BCE, and Greek culture spreads throughout the Middle East.

GODS

The Greeks had many gods, ruled over by Zeus and his wife Hera. Festivals and sacrifices were important in the daily religious life of the city-states. Women rarely had any role in public life, but a few were priestesses who played an important part in rituals and celebrations.



ZEUS

GREEK ALPHABET

The Ancient Greeks had an alphabet of 24 letters – the first to have vowels as well as consonants. The word “alphabet” comes from the first two letters, alpha and beta.

Α	Β	Γ	Δ	Ε	Ζ
ALPHA	BETA	GAMMA	DELTA	EPSILON	ZETA
Η	Θ	Ι	Κ	Λ	Μ
ETA	THETA	IOTA	KAPPA	LAMBDA	MU
Ν	Ξ	Ο	Π	Ρ	Σ
NU	XI	OMICRON	PI	RHO	SIGMA
Τ	Υ	Φ	Χ	Ψ	Ω
TAU	UPSILON	PHI	CHI	PSI	OMEGA

WAR AND ARMOUR

The main fighting force of the Greek city-states were hoplites, heavily armoured foot-soldiers who carried a large round shield, or *hoplon*. They fought in phalanxes (shield walls), several rows deep, to protect the soldiers.



HOPLITE ARMOUR

WEAPON CALLED “KOPIS” IN SHEATH



XIPHOS, ANCIENT GREEK SWORD



WARRIOR SHIELD (HOPLON)



SOLDIER'S AXE AND SANDAL



ANCIENT GREEK ARMY HELMET

GREAT THINKERS

Around 600 BCE, Greek thinkers began to use logic instead of religion to think about the world and how it works. Their ideas were the beginning of philosophy.

- **PYTHAGORAS (c.530 BCE)**
A theorem for working out the length of the sides of a right-angled triangle still bears the name of Pythagoras. He also believed that numbers had mystical powers.
- **SOCRATES (469–399 BCE)**
This Athenian philosopher taught his students to question the power of Athens' ruling classes. He was put to death for his views.
- **PLATO (427–347 BCE)**
Socrates' pupil Plato believed people should live their lives trying to reach absolute moral goodness. His ideas are still studied today.
- **ARISTOTLE (384–322 BCE)**
This pupil of Plato founded a school called the Lyceum. He wrote many important works about biology, zoology, physics, logic, and politics.
- **ARCHIMEDES (c.287–212 BCE)**
This engineer and mathematician invented a screw pump that drew up water, and wrote a theorem to calculate the area of a circle.



PLATO